

SARK SOUL ISLAND RETREATS

# Getting to Sark

An honest guide to the slowest island in the Channel, and how to reach it.



YOGA & NATURE RETREATS · ISLE OF SARK

# Why this guide exists

Most guides to Sark repeat three facts. There are no cars. The cliffs are dramatic. The night sky is dark.

These things are true, but they do not begin to explain how special Sark is, or why a few days on Sark feels like a deeper reset than a week in a conventional destination. This guide is an attempt to do just that. It is written to be honest enough to trust. It is not written to persuade you that Sark is for everyone, because it is not.

A century ago, two brothers from Lancashire wrote a guide to this Island, and in doing so set a bar that all others have subsequently struggled to reach. Geoffrey and Leslie La Trobe Foster spent three summers on Sark; they were fifteen and nineteen on that first visit from 1911 to 1913. They published their guide in 1914, and within months went from this account of a carefree paradise island to the trenches of the First World War.

No one has described Sark better since, save perhaps their own descendants, who brought the guide back into print. We recommend it without reservation. The 1914 words throughout these pages are theirs.

*"To all.. the unique beauties of the island must appeal, the rugged sea line, its sea views and caves, its ever changing colours in heather, gorse and flowers, the beautiful colours and contours of its rocks, whether at morning, noon, or night, its wonderful sunsets, and ever varying sea tints. Truly a wonderful little island that lies so near our homes and, as yet, so little known."*

THE LATROBES, SARK, JULY 1914

# The crossing

The boat from Guernsey takes 35 to 55 minutes, and the moment you leave, the mainland and your to-do list let go of you.

Getting to Sark takes effort. There is no airport, no way on but the sea. The modern world has spent a century engineering friction out of travel. Sark gives it back, and that is the point, not the price.

None of this is enforced. There is wifi, there is phone signal, the modern world is entirely available here. The island simply has a way of reordering what matters, until a day or two in you stop reaching for your phone, and you don't decide to.



OUT OF GUERNSEY, THE ONLY WAY TO SARK, THEN AND NOW

It is a serious sea, this one. The tide runs ten metres twice a day, among the greatest ranges on earth, which is why the crossing has never grown shorter. The Corsaire de Sercq makes the run today, as the Fleet Commodore did before her, and the Courier before that. Isle of Sark Shipping runs it year-round from White Rock, in St Peter Port: frequent in summer, sparse in winter, gone altogether on the wild days. Book at [sarkshipping.gg](http://sarkshipping.gg).

In fair weather the boat comes in past Jethou, Herm low to the west, threading the rocks toward the cliffs. The island arrives in pieces: the mill on the skyline, the stone finger of the Pilcher Monument, the Gouliot channel where Brecqhou breaks away, then the bays, one after another, into Maseline. Watch the water. The dolphins run these currents, and on a good day they ride the hull to the harbour mouth and turn back, having brought you as far as they mean to.

# Getting to Guernsey first



ST PETER PORT, WHERE THE SARK BOAT BEGINS

Everything starts with Guernsey.

By air, Guernsey is about 45 minutes from Gatwick and under an hour from several regional airports; Aurigny flies the most routes. By sea, Condor runs fast ferries from the English south coast in around two and a half hours, and from St Malo in about two. From April to September, Manche Iles Express sails to Sark directly from Jersey and the Normandy ports.

One rule above all. Leave room between your flight and the boat. The crossing won't wait for a late arrival, and with sailings spaced through the day, missing one can cost you hours, occasionally a night in Guernsey.

For the airport-to-harbour leg, a pre-booked car that watches your flight saves the stress. We use Platinum Executive Services and their standard arm [Taxi2Where](#), a Guernsey firm that tracks arrivals and handles both ends of your trip.

## The harbour, the climb, and the carters

You don't land at the village. You land at the foot of a cliff.

Maseline is the working harbour, usable at any tide. Creux, around the headland, is the older one, a small walled cove the islanders cut in the 1580s, kept now for the days the wind shuts Maseline. From either, the only way is up: twenty minutes on foot through a wooded valley, or the tractor-drawn bus everyone calls the toast rack.



A SARK COVE, NO CARS HAVE EVER RUN HERE

The toast rack has a good story behind it. For centuries the climb was made on foot or by horse, until the 1970s, when the crowds grew and someone took pity on the horses hauling load after load up the hill. The tractor took the heavy work; the horses still meet you at the top for the gentler journey on.

Leave it to the carters. You won't carry your bags up. Label them, leave them on the quay, and they find their own way to you. Your only job on arrival is to get yourself to the top.

## Around her coast, by boat

*"The bathing, the rocks, the pools, and the climbing are so varied and charming that the visitor is at first almost bewildered in the midst of so great a profusion of delights."*

LA TROBE, 1914

Much of Sark's coast has no path. The great sea caves, the arches, the caverns at the waterline: you reach them only from the water. In the La Trobes' day the trip round the island meant a rowing boat, two boatmen and most of a day. Now it is a little over two hours with the Guille family, who have run these waters for generations, leaving from Creux twice a day in season. Their wooden boat the Non Pareil was lost not long ago, much mourned; the trip runs today aboard the Dorado, rebuilt for the purpose in 2024.



THE COAST THAT HAS NO PATH, REACHED ONLY FROM THE SEA

It is also the gentler way to see the coast if scrambling isn't for you, and in season the wildlife comes with it: puffins, guillemots, dolphins, seals, the occasional basking shark. The tide does the rest. With a ten-metre range, no two trips are alike; some days you slip into the caves, others you nearly touch the offshore rocks, and on the lowest tides the boatmen show you ground that lies underwater the rest of the month.

By the water. Round-island trips and private charters: Sark Boat Trips, [sarkboattrips.com](https://sarkboattrips.com). For a group, a charter to L'Etac's seabird colonies, an evening run, or a quiet bay with paddleboards and lunch can be arranged direct.

## STAY LONGER

# Why a day isn't enough

*"To know Sark thoroughly would take a lifetime of holidays."*

LA TROBE, 1914

Most people give Sark an afternoon. They walk a lane, photograph the cliffs, and catch the last boat back having missed the island entirely.

Don't rush the crossing. Leave a generous margin at St Peter Port rather than sprinting for the quay. The boat connects with flights but won't wait for them, and arriving unhurried is half the point.

Pack soft, and light. No cars and a tractor for the hill make hard suitcases a nuisance; a holdall or rucksack is far easier. You'll need less than you think. The island runs on layers, good shoes and a free evening.

Let it set the pace. Distance here is measured in time, not miles, and nothing can be hurried. Most people stop trying within an hour or two, usually without noticing.



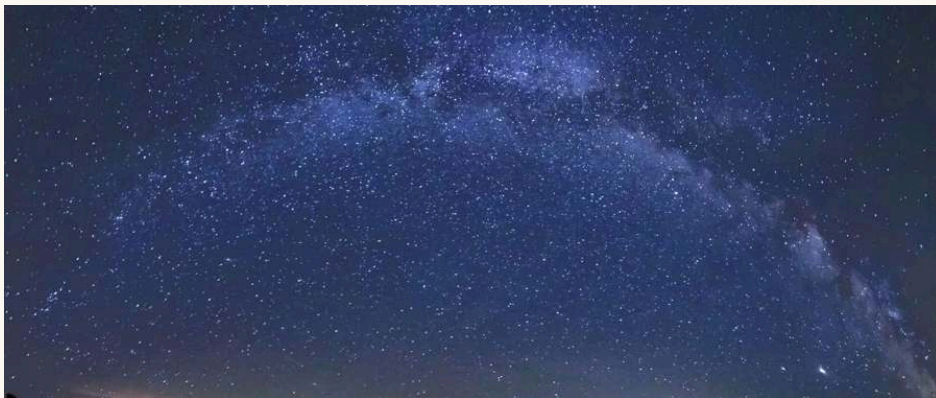
SPRING ON THE COAST PATH, THE ISLAND REWARDS THOSE WHO STAY



# The darkest sky in Britain

Sark was the world's first Dark Sky Island, named in 2011. With no street lighting, the nights are genuinely black, and the stars are the kind most people have never seen: the Milky Way edge to edge, the lights of half a dozen lighthouses ranged across the sea.

Look up on a clear night and you are seeing roughly what the brothers saw, and what the people who raised the island's standing stones saw four thousand years before them. Very little has come between.



THE MILKY WAY OVER SARK, THE WORLD'S FIRST DARK SKY ISLAND

## WORTH PACKING

- ✓ Layers, it's cooler by the sea
- ✓ Proper walking shoes
- ✓ A waterproof or windproof
- ✓ A torch for the lanes at night
- ✓ Swimwear, for the brave
- ✓ A refillable water bottle
- ✓ Any medication you need



WHEN YOU COME TO US

## Arriving for your retreat

The logistics become ours. Once you've booked, the planning stops being yours. We send a simple arrival note: which sailing to aim for, where we'll meet you, how your bags reach the house. From the moment you step off the boat, the logistics are ours.

Most guests fly into Guernsey in the morning, take an early-afternoon boat, and are settled into the house by late afternoon, in time to unpack, breathe, and gather for the first evening together.



HOME FOR THE WEEK, OUR HISTORIC FARMHOUSE ON SARK

OUR NEXT RETREAT

## 12 to 17 September 2026

Five nights, a small group of no more than twelve. Places are limited, and the early booking rate closes 19 July.

RESERVE YOUR PLACE

*"Once a visit has been paid to Sark, the visitor always longs to repeat, in following years, the happy weeks of his previous holiday in the Pearl of Islands." - The Latrobes, 1914*